

As the monk Kevala carries the maiden Mandakini (named after a tributary of the Alaknanda River), he is helped to cross another river—physical, material symbolisms are layered over in Varma's text. Suppressed or just latent, intuitive lust so naturally intertwines with wafts of spiritualism, the battle of the head and the heart ensues. Readers will relate to their tempestuous journeys and how they came to still their waters or were simply washed away.

A wise book teaches by suggestion, not command, because just one variable in two comparable lives changes the whole path. The sub-title of the book calls it 'A Parable for Ordinary People', but as the author strews his pearls, maybe his readers will discover that some special insights that could awaken them to extraordinary aspects lay buried within themselves? ■

THE QUICK, SPIRITUAL READ THROWS UP **NEW WAYS OF SEEING, ESPECIALLY FOR THOSE WITH SOME GREY** IN THEIR HAIR

—Aman Nath

now set to write two major travel books on India. At the recently concluded Kerala Literature Festival, he said that while the first book will cover Rajasthan and parts of Uttar Pradesh, the second will explore the southern part of the country.

"I have been coming to India ever since I was 12, and the fascination with its people and places has only grown. India has not changed emotionally for me, though there have been several political and social changes," says the author, who does not like to 'invent' stories and insists that real ones are far more fascinating. "You cannot even dream of devising tales that real life throws at you—who could imagine a character like the US president Trump? Of course, non-fiction must boast of fiction's crispness and read like a novel."

As someone who makes an annual pilgrimage to Bhopal, since he supports the Sambhavna Clinic for the victims of the gas tragedy, Moro laments that despite all the infrastructure development in his favourite country, little attention is paid to heritage. "No one seems to be interested in encouraging tourism in India. There is so much this country has to offer, but little effort is put into ensuring that centuries-old buildings are maintained," he says. Stressing that his 'outsider' viewpoint lends him a peculiar objectivity and a unique perspective, he adds, "The best history books on Spanish history are written by the British. Can you negate the fantastic work done by William Dalrymple on India's past?" ■

—Sukant Deepak

TREADING NEW GROUND

ANANYA VAJPEYI'S *PLACE* IS A JOURNEY INWARDS AS MUCH AS IT IS ABOUT EXPERIENCING THE WORLD

In *Place: Intimate Encounters with Cities*, author Ananya Vajpeyi not only takes the reader across the globe through her experiences, but also into the internal landscape of humanity. The central premise of this collection of essays written over 25 years and spanning 13 cities is that 'place' is not merely a set of GPS coordinates or a patch of soil; it is a vessel for memory, culture and the sacred.



PLACE: Intimate Encounters with Cities
By Ananya Vajpeyi
WOMEN UNLIMITED INK
₹625; 239 pages

The historian, political theorist and established writer blends pedagogy with vibrant detail, incisive insights with poetic beauty. She allows her personal experiences to shine a light on interesting aspects of these cities and yet manages to ask the key questions, seeking answers that are not mired in the myopic and the mundane. Be it a surreal Sufi encounter, a disdainful (yet accurate) word picture of old Bengaluru and the new "tawdry Silicon Valley", or the caste politics of Mumbai's Shivaji Park, Vajpeyi wields her writing like a sword that cuts through all the presets and prejudices. As you allow the concepts to sink in, you realise *Place* isn't just about where you are physically, but where you are in life; and that to be human is to perennially seek one's 'rightful place' in the world.

Ultimately, *Place* is a call to attentiveness. It invites us to stop treating our surroundings as mere backdrops for our lives and to start seeing them as active participants in our story. It's a reminder that while we may travel far, our identity is always anchored somewhere, waiting for us to recognise it. ■

—Priya Pathiyan